That is a striking claim. Who is Greenwald to decide who is 'innocent' and who is not? Are all employees of the NSA to be counted as 'guilty' of engaging in 'dirty work'? And everyone who cooperates with them? Or only some? And guilty of what? Is Greenwald the judge, jury and executioner of the careers of public servants who have operated within the law, at the behest of elected governments, and under the oversight of courts and lawmakers?

It is only a mild caricature to say that the presumption behind the leaks is that the intelligence agencies in the West are the greatest threat to freedom on the planet. As Inkster argues, 'for those who regard intelligence services as inherently illegitimate or take the view that the US is the world's number-one rogue actor, no counter-narrative will ever be convincing'. Such fears may be the basis for a thrilling screenplay in a Hollywood movie, where vast sinister forces are marshalled against a lone hero. But they are a poor guide to real life.

One of the overwhelming impressions left by the leaked documents is, in fact, of a painstaking approach to legality. The spies did not believe that what they wrote would ever become public. Like other bureaucrats, they trumpeted their achievements in the hope of scoring points and winning favour. That comes across sometimes as chirpy or crass. But nothing revealed shows contempt for judicial oversight or a wilful desire to evade it.[61]

The NSA and other agencies do try to work out what the maximum is that they can do within the limits of the law. In some cases, they overstep the mark and get slapped down, sometimes crossly, by the FISC or Congress; moreover, individual officers of the agencies may knowingly break the rules. But the fact that these breaches were recorded in internal agency documents (and in the case of individual wrongdoing, disciplined) bespeaks adherence to procedure, not a cover-up.

Moreover, to err is human: bureaucratic self-aggrandisement is common in other branches of